

fever was to find oil, not gold, and it was an epidemic. There were few, indeed, who were immune to the contagion. Fortunes were being made—and lost—daily. It was not unusual for a penniless wildcatter, down to his last bit and without cash or credit with which to buy more, to drill another hundred feet and bring in a well that made him a rich man. A lease which sold for a few hundred dollars one afternoon sometimes increased in value a hundredfold or even a thousand fold by the next morning.

On the other hand, there were men who invested all they owned in leases and drilling operations only to find that they had nothing to show for their money and efforts but a few dismally dry holes. Leases purchased at peak prices one day proved to be utterly valueless the next. It was all a supremely thrilling gamble for staggering stakes, and I plunged into the whirl hopefully. I had no capital of my own; my personal budget was \$100 per month. My first year was anything but profitable. Large oil strikes were being reported regularly, and other wildcatters were bringing in gushers and big producers, but fortune seemed to elude me.

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Then, in the late fall of 1915, a half-interest in an oil lease near Stone Bluff in Muskogee County—the Nancy Taylor Allotment—was offered for sale at public auction. I inspected the property and thought it highly promising. I knew other independent operators were interested in obtaining the lease, and this worried me. I didn't have much money at my disposal—certainly not enough to match the prices older, established oilmen would be able to offer. For this reason, I requested my bank to have one of its representatives bid for me at the sale without revealing my identity as the real bidder.

Surprisingly enough, this rather transparent stratagem accomplished the purpose I intended. The sale, held in the town of Muskogee—the county seat—was attended by several independent oil operators eager to obtain the lease.

The unexpected appearance of the well-known bank executive who bid for me unnerved the wildcatters. They assumed that if a banker was present at the auction, it could only mean that some large oil company was also interested in the property and was prepared to top any and all offers. The